

Are We Protecting the Gods of Bible?

The old temples are gone. The old acts are not. The Bible names a crowd of gods. One of them is still worshiped by nations. The rest lost their statues, their poles, and their priests. What the law protects now is not a carved Baal. It is the things those cults did: sex cut loose from marriage, men paraded as women, enchantment sold in the shop, and the killing of children with the parents' consent and the public's blessing.

Jonathan Cahn's *The Return of the Gods* (FrontLine, 2022) says the cults died and the descriptions did not. This presentation tests that claim. The first half is the gods, with Scripture. The second half is the practices, with the records and the laws that shelter them.

I. The gods named in Scripture

The God who is still worshiped

The God of Israel is not a relic. His personal name, YHWH, appears more than six thousand times in the Hebrew Bible. Jews still worship Him. Christians worship Him as the Father of Jesus Christ. That is the one named God in the Book who still has a people, a prayer, and a public confession.

Everyone else on this list is a rival the prophets told Israel to smash.

Islam is not in the Book

The Bible does not teach Islam. It never names Muhammad, the Quran, Mecca, or a Muslim. Islam begins in the seventh century. Muhammad dies in 632. The New Testament was already written. There is no verse that lays out the Five Pillars, the denial of the Son, or a prophet from Arabia.

What the Bible does say about the family Islam later claims is this. Ishmael, Abraham's son by Hagar, will become a great nation.

"As for Ishmael, I have heard you; behold, I have blessed him and will make him fruitful and multiply him greatly. He shall father twelve princes, and I will make him into a great nation."

Genesis 17:20

"And I will make a nation of the son of the slave woman also, because he is your offspring."

Genesis 21:13

That is a promise about a people. It is not a sketch of Islam. Genesis 16:12 says Ishmael will be a wild donkey of a man, his hand against everyone and everyone's hand against him. Genesis 25:12–18 lists his sons and says they settled from Havilah to Shur. The text stops there. It does not build a mosque.

Two passages are dragged in later to force Muhammad into the Book. Neither one is about him.

Moses promised Israel a prophet like himself, from among their brothers, and said God would put His words in that prophet's mouth (Deuteronomy 18:15–18). Peter stands up in Jerusalem and says that prophet is Jesus (Acts 3:22–26). The brothers in that sentence are Israel, not a later Arab nation.

Jesus promised another Helper. He said the Father would send the Helper, the Holy Spirit, in His name, and that the Helper would teach them and glorify Him (John 14:16–17, 26; 16:7–15). The Helper is the

Spirit of God. He is not a man born five centuries later.

Islam's own book teaches what the Bible refuses. The Quran denies that God has a Son, and it denies that Jesus was killed on the cross. The New Testament says the man who denies the Son does not have the Father (1 John 2:22–23), and that every spirit that does not confess Jesus Christ has come in the flesh is not from God (1 John 4:1–3). Paul says that if anyone preaches another gospel, let him be accursed (Galatians 1:8–9).

Arabic-speaking Jews and Christians were already calling the God of the Bible “Allah,” because that is the Arabic word for God. Using the word does not make the religions the same. Islam tells its people to deny the cross and the Son. The Bible calls that a different gospel.

Baal

Baal means lord, owner, husband, master. He was the Canaanite storm and sex-and-crop god. In the King James concordance his name, singular and plural (Baal and Baalim), is counted eighty times (Strong's H1168: Baal 62, Baalim 18).

Israel walked off the Lord and into Baal as soon as Joshua's generation died.

“And the people of Israel did what was evil in the sight of the LORD and served the Baals. And they abandoned the LORD, the God of their fathers, who had brought them out of the land of Egypt. They went after other gods, from among the gods of the peoples who were around them, and bowed down to them.”

Judges 2:11–12

“They abandoned the LORD and served the Baals and the Ashtaroht.”

Judges 2:13

Gideon tore down his father's Baal altar and cut down the Asherah pole beside it (Judges 6:25–32). Ahab built Baal a temple in Samaria and set up an Asherah (1 Kings 16:31–33). Elijah faced four hundred fifty prophets of Baal on Carmel. They shouted, limped around the altar, and cut themselves with swords and lances until the blood poured (1 Kings 18:25–29). Fire fell on the Lord's sacrifice. The prophets of Baal were killed (1 Kings 18:38–40). Jehu demolished the temple and turned the pillar of Baal into a latrine (2 Kings 10:18–28). Josiah burned Baal's vessels (2 Kings 23:4–5).

The prophets did not treat Baal as a harmless farm spirit. Jeremiah says they built the high places of Baal to burn their sons in the fire as offerings to Baal, a thing God never commanded and that never entered His mind (Jeremiah 19:5; 32:35). Hosea's whole marriage is a picture of Israel cheating on the Lord with Baal (Hosea 2).

No nation still runs a Baal temple. The name is dead as a public religion. A few private pagans have picked it back up. That is a hobby, not a culture with courts behind it.

Asherah

Asherah was the goddess set beside Baal, and the word is also the wooden pole, the “grove,” planted as her idol. The name and those poles come up about forty times.

God's order was simple. Cut them down.

“You shall tear down their altars and break their pillars and cut down their Asherim.”

Exodus 34:13

“You shall not plant any tree as an Asherah beside the altar of the LORD your God that you shall make.”

Deuteronomy 16:21

Deuteronomy 7:5 and 12:3 say the same: smash the altars, burn the images, chop the poles. Manasseh put a carved Asherah in the Lord’s own temple (2 Kings 21:7). Josiah dragged it out, burned it, and beat it to dust (2 Kings 23:6). Four hundred prophets of Asherah ate at Jezebel’s table (1 Kings 18:19).

The pole is not a protected civic symbol anywhere that still knows what it is.

Ashtoreth

Ashtoreth, plural Ashtarothe, is the Sidonian goddess. She is the Bible’s name for the sex-and-war goddess the nations called Astarte and Ishtar. She is named with Baal in Judges 2:13 and 10:6. Samuel tells Israel to put away the foreign gods and the Ashtarothe, and they do (1 Samuel 7:3–4; 12:10). The Philistines hang Saul’s armor in the temple of Ashtarothe (1 Samuel 31:10). Solomon builds her a high place east of Jerusalem, “Ashtoreth the abomination of the Sidonians” (1 Kings 11:5, 33). Josiah defiles that high place (2 Kings 23:13).

Her public cult died. Her job description did not. That is the second half of this paper.

Molech

Molech, also spelled Moloch, is the Ammonite god whose worship was the burning of children.

“You shall not give any of your children to offer them to Molech, and so profane the name of your God: I am the LORD.”

Leviticus 18:21

The penalty is death. God says He will cut off the man who gives his child to Molech, and He will cut off the family and the nation that closes its eyes and refuses to stop him (Leviticus 20:2–5). Solomon built Molech a high place on the hill east of Jerusalem (1 Kings 11:7). Josiah defiled Topheth in the Valley of the Son of Hinnom so no one would make a son or a daughter pass through the fire to Molech (2 Kings 23:10). Jeremiah 32:35 says they offered their sons and daughters to Molech on the high places of Baal. Stephen, quoting the prophets, says Israel took along the star of their god Rephan and the images they made to worship (Acts 7:43; Amos 5:26 names Moloch).

The name shows up on the order of ten times, clustered in those passages. Nobody in a Western capital bows to a bronze Molech and beats drums so the crowd will not hear the child. The fire pit is gone. The handing over of the child is not. That, too, is the second half.

Milcom

Milcom, or Maltam, is the god of the Ammonites, often paired with Molech and sometimes treated as the same abomination under another title. Solomon went after Ashtoreth and after Milcom the abomination of the Ammonites (1 Kings 11:5, 33). Josiah defiled the high places Solomon had built for Ashtoreth, Chemosh, and Milcom (2 Kings 23:13). Zephaniah condemns those who bow and swear to the Lord and also swear by Milcom (Zephaniah 1:5). That is the biblical picture of a mixed religion: God’s name on the lips, another god in the oath.

His cult is dead.

Chemosh

Chemosh is the god of Moab. He is named eight times: Numbers 21:29, Judges 11:24, 1 Kings 11:7, 1 Kings 11:33, 2 Kings 23:13, Jeremiah 48:7, Jeremiah 48:13, and Jeremiah 48:46. Moab is called the people of Chemosh. Solomon built him a high place. Josiah tore the worship down. Jeremiah mocks Chemosh going into exile with his priests.

Second Kings 3:27 shows what his kind of worship cost. The king of Moab, losing the battle, took his oldest son, the heir, and offered him as a burnt offering on the wall. The cult is dead. Burning the firstborn to buy a result is the part that keeps finding a new legal name.

Dagon

Dagon was the god of the Philistines. They praise him when Samson is captured (Judges 16:23). They put the ark of God in Dagon's temple in Ashdod. In the morning Dagon is flat on his face before the ark. They set him back up. The next morning he is down again, and his head and both hands are cut off on the threshold (1 Samuel 5:2–5). The lords of the Philistines fasten Saul's head in the temple of Dagon (1 Chronicles 10:10). Place-names such as Beth-dagon (Joshua 15:41; 19:27) remember him. His worship does not.

Tammuz

Tammuz is named once. Ezekiel is shown the temple, and at the north gate sit women weeping for Tammuz (Ezekiel 8:14). He was the young god, the lover of Ishtar, mourned as dead and waited on as returning. One verse. No living public cult.

The Queen of Heaven

Jeremiah does not give her a personal name. The people do. The children gather wood, the fathers kindle the fire, and the women knead dough to make cakes for the Queen of Heaven, and they pour out drink offerings to other gods (Jeremiah 7:18). Later the refugees in Egypt refuse the prophet to his face. They say they will keep burning incense to the Queen of Heaven and pouring out drink offerings, because when they did it they had plenty of food, and when they stopped they lacked everything (Jeremiah 44:15–19). God calls that worship an abomination and says the plenty they remember was the very thing He was judging (Jeremiah 44:20–23).

That passage matters for the second half. They do not argue that she is the true God. They argue that her rites are the culture that kept them safe, and they will not give the rites up.

Bel, Nebo, and the imported gods

Isaiah pictures Babylon's gods as baggage on a cart.

“Bel bows down; Nebo stoops; their idols are on beasts and livestock; these things you carry are borne as burdens on weary beasts.”

Isaiah 46:1

Jeremiah says Babylon is taken and Bel is put to shame, Merodach is dismayed (Jeremiah 50:2), and God will punish Bel in Babylon (Jeremiah 51:44).

Second Kings 17:30–31 is a junk drawer of gods the Assyrians planted in Samaria, each named once: Succoth-benoth, Nergal, Ashima, Nibhaz, Tartak, Adrammelech, and Anammelech. Of the last two the text says the Sepharvites burned their children in the fire to them. One verse. No surviving church of Nergal.

Egypt, Greece, and Rome

Egypt's gods are judged as a class. "On all the gods of Egypt I will execute judgments: I am the LORD" (Exodus 12:12). "The LORD executed judgments against their gods" (Numbers 33:4). The Bible does not stop to catalog Isis and Osiris. The state cult of Egypt is not a living religion.

In Lystra the crowd decides Barnabas is Zeus and Paul is Hermes, and the priest of Zeus brings oxen to sacrifice (Acts 14:12–13). Paul tears his clothes and tells them to turn from these empty things to the living God (Acts 14:15). In Ephesus, Demetrius the silversmith starts a riot because Paul's preaching is wrecking the trade in silver shrines of Artemis (Acts 19:23–41). The town clerk's concern is the city's reputation and Artemis's legal worship. On the ship to Rome, the figurehead is the twin gods, Castor and Pollux (Acts 28:11). One line. Those civic cults are museum pieces.

What the count comes to

The God of Israel is named thousands of times and is still worshiped. Baal is named about eighty times. Asherah about forty. Dagon in a short cluster around Judges 16, 1 Samuel 5, and 1 Chronicles 10. Molech about ten times. Milcom a handful. Chemosh eight. Ashtoreth in Judges, Samuel, and Kings. Tammuz once. Bel and Nebo a few lines. The Samarian imports once each. Zeus, Hermes, and Artemis one scene each.

Islam is not on the list at all.

The statues fell. That is not the end of the question. The Bible's charge against these gods was never only that the wood was carved. It was what the worshipers did with their bodies and with their children, and how fiercely they defended those acts as the life of the people.

II. The practices, and the culture that shelters them

Eight practices define this cult complex in the Bible and in the old hymns of Ishtar. Seven of them now have a legal and cultural shelter in the West. The eighth, the named altar, does not, because nobody is keeping it.

Cahn sorts the three principal spirits as Baal the possessor, Ishtar the enchantress, and Molech the destroyer (*The Return of the Gods*, 2022). The verses below are older than his book. So are the hymns. The court cases are newer. Read them side by side.

1. Another lord over the public

Baal's work was to take a people who had known the Lord and put a different master over ordinary life. The high place replaced the altar. The Lord's name became the awkward thing.

"How long will you go limping between two different opinions? If the LORD is God, follow him; but if Baal, then follow him."

1 Kings 18:21

America did not erect a Baal statue in the schoolyard. It emptied the school of prayer to the God of the Bible and called the emptiness a right. In *Engel v. Vitale*, 370 U.S. 421 (1962), the Supreme Court struck down a short state-written prayer in the public schools. In *Abington School District v. Schempp*, 374 U.S. 203 (1963), it struck down devotional Bible reading. The public house was cleared. Into a cleared house, Scripture says, other spirits move (Matthew 12:43–45, the parable Cahn uses for a nation). Hostility to the name of Jesus in the public square is now treated as neutrality. Neutrality toward Baal was never what the prophets required. They required the pole to come down.

2. Shrine sex, then sex as the culture

The Bible does not blush about this, and it does not call it romance. It calls it cult prostitution, male and female, attached to the worship.

“You shall not bring the fee of a prostitute or the wages of a dog into the house of the LORD your God in payment for any vow, for both of these are an abomination to the LORD your God.”

Deuteronomy 23:18

The verse before it forbids an Israelite woman to be a cult prostitute and an Israelite man to be a cult prostitute (Deuteronomy 23:17). Older English Bibles used the word “sodomite” for the man. The Hebrew is *qadesh*, the male set apart for the shrine. Rehoboam’s generation had male cult prostitutes in the land, and Judah did the abominations of the nations (1 Kings 14:24). Asa drove them out (1 Kings 15:12). Jehoshaphat drove out the rest (1 Kings 22:46). Josiah tore down their houses, and those houses were at the Lord’s temple, where women wove hangings for the Asherah (2 Kings 23:7). Hosea says the men go aside with whores and sacrifice with cult prostitutes (Hosea 4:14).

Herodotus, in *Histories* 1.199, claims that in Babylon every woman, once in her life, had to sit in the temple of the goddess and have sex with a stranger. Assyriologists have shown that Babylonian temple records do not confirm his report. The Bible does not need Herodotus. It already says the shrines kept male and female prostitutes, and that Israel put them next to the holy place.

That temple duty is not the law of any American state. What is the law is the thing the shrine was selling: sex pulled loose from the marriage bed and treated as the adult’s right. *Griswold v. Connecticut*, 381 U.S. 479 (1965), and *Eisenstadt v. Baird*, 405 U.S. 438 (1972), built a privacy right around contraception, for the married and then for the unmarried. *Lawrence v. Texas*, 539 U.S. 558 (2003), struck down the remaining laws against private homosexual sex. The culture that followed does not fine fornication. It advertises it. The bed is no longer the covenant. The bed is the god.

The temple and the blessing

Nobody keeps a public list of countries where a secret society sells sex as the price of rank. A number printed here would be a guess, and a guess does not belong in this paper. The orders do not register the rite as prostitution. Search the statute books for temple prostitution and the count is zero. That empty count is the disguise.

What the brothers say is older and plainer. They go to the temple. They go for a blessing. Fraternal houses have talked that way for a long time. The meeting room is the temple. The rite that admits a man, or lifts him, is called a blessing. Those two words are common. They are not, by themselves, a confession of bought sex. A college secret society can build a windowless temple and mean a tapping ritual, a Bible, and a key. Swarthmore’s Book and Key did that from 1906, in a building it called the Temple, on the pattern of

the Yale senior societies. The minutes that survive describe the tap, the hour, and the initiation. They do not describe a whore hired so a man could buy a higher chair.

When the sex is real, it uses the same two words, and the records are blunt. In eighteenth-century Scotland the club called itself the Beggar's Benison, which means the beggar's blessing. The members met in a room they called the temple. A man was not in the order until he had performed a sex act in front of the brothers. Women were hired for the meeting. Rank was not a lecture. Rank was the act. David Stevenson's study of the order's own papers, *The Beggar's Benison: Sex Clubs of Enlightenment Scotland* (2001), is the record. That is shrine sex with the shrine renamed a fraternal temple and the fee renamed a blessing.

A later occult lodge, the Ordo Templi Orientis, wrote sexual acts into the higher degrees and did the work in a temple. Its lodges have sat in more than one country. That is the doctrine of one small order. It is not a map of the nations, and it is not the bylaws of every Greek-letter house.

Where sex is the toll for an inner rank and the woman is not free to refuse, the courts have called it a crime. NXIVM, in the United States, kept a secret inner circle in which sexual servitude was the price of standing. Keith Raniere was convicted for it. One prosecuted order is not a census of the world.

So the paper cannot close on the line that the temple prostitute's room simply vanished. The public room, with the goddess named on the door, is gone. The private room is talked about as a temple and a blessing. How many countries still run that room? There is no honest tally, because the ones that only mean a meeting hall are not the rite, and the ones that mean the rite do not file it under prostitution. The act is the old act. The label is what changed.

3. Sexual images as a trade

Ishtar's hymns put desire and arousal in her hand. In the Sumerian hymn *Inana C*, the block of lines 115–131 is blunt: "To turn a man into a woman and a woman into a man are yours, Inana. Desirability and arousal, goods and property are yours, Inana." (Electronic Text Corpus of Sumerian Literature, t.4.07.3.) Sex and profit sit in the same list.

The modern trade is pornography: pictures and film of people having sex, sold as a product, piped into the house. Adult material is protected speech unless it is legally obscene under *Miller v. California*, 413 U.S. 15 (1973). *Reno v. ACLU*, 521 U.S. 844 (1997), knocked down the first big attempt to fence the internet against indecency. The product is legal, mainstream, and defended as liberty.

Draw the line the law itself draws. Sexual images of children are not protected. *New York v. Ferber*, 458 U.S. 747 (1982), holds that child pornography is a crime, outside the First Amendment. The cult-parallel claimed here is the adult sex trade in images, not the rape of children on camera. Those are different sins, and the second one the state still punishes.

4. Men dressed as women, women dressed as men, in a public parade

This is not a modern invention read back into a vague myth. The hymn to Inana for Ishme-Dagan says the goddess was given the power "to turn a man into a woman and a woman into a man, to change one into the other, to make young women dress as men on their right side, to make young men dress as women on their left side, to put spindles into the hands of men, and to give weapons to the women." (ETCSL t.2.5.4.11, lines 19–31.)

Her cult staff matched the hymn. The *assinnu* and the *kurgarru* served Ishtar. They cross-dressed, danced in her rites, and showed up in her processions. Martti Nissinen's entry on the *assinnu* in *The*

Encyclopedia of Ancient History records them as her devotees from the third millennium through the first, occupied with cross-dressing, ritual dance, healing, and prophecy. Older scholars translated the title “male cult prostitute.” That translation is now disputed. The cross-dressing and the goddess’s claimed power to flip the sexes are not disputed. They are in the hymns.

A later goddess cult in the same family, the Syrian goddess and the Phrygian Cybele, pushed the body further. Lucian, in *On the Syrian Goddess* 50–51, describes the galli: priests who castrate themselves for the goddess and parade in women’s clothing. Catullus 63 is the same priesthood, Attis unmanned for Cybele. That is not an Ishtar tablet from Ur. It is the same kind of worship, centuries later, still cutting the male body and dressing the man as a woman for a goddess.

Set that next to the parades now guarded as civic pride. Men dressed as women, women dressed as men, sex boundaries treated as the thing to break, in a public procession the city permits, sponsors, and celebrates. Assembly and speech protect the parade. *Obergefell v. Hodges*, 576 U.S. 644 (2015), made same-sex marriage the law of the United States. *Bostock v. Clayton County*, 590 U.S. 644 (2020), read federal employment law so that firing a person for homosexual conduct or for being transgender is illegal sex discrimination. The ancient cult did not issue marriage licenses. What it did do is on the hymn tablet: it flipped the clothes, flipped the sexes, and marched it through the street as worship. The march is legal. The goddess’s name has been dropped. The description has not.

5. Remaking the sexed body

The galli did it with a knife. The hymn claimed the goddess could turn a man into a woman and a woman into a man. The current form is hormones and surgery: a male body chemically and surgically pushed toward a female appearance, a female body pushed toward a male one, and the result called the person’s real sex. For adults, that course is legal in the United States and is fenced by the same employment and public-accommodation rules *Bostock* reshaped.

For children the shelter has started to crack, and the crack is in the medical record, not in a pulpit. Sweden’s National Board of Health and Welfare, in its December 2022 guidelines on the care of children and adolescents with gender dysphoria, judged that at the group level the risks of puberty blockers and hormones are likely to outweigh the benefits, and it issued a weak negative recommendation. Dr. Hilary Cass’s *Independent Review of Gender Identity Services for Children and Young People*, delivered to NHS England in April 2024, found the evidence for puberty blockers weak, the rationale for early suppression unclear, and the effect on sexual and cognitive development unknown. NHS England stopped routine puberty blockers for minors. The United Kingdom then restricted new prescriptions.

So say it plainly. The adult version of remaking the body across the sex line is still protected culture. The child version has been rolled back in Britain and Sweden because the doctors could not show it was safe. The goddess’s hymn did not wait for a clinical trial. It simply announced that turning a man into a woman was her property.

6. Enchantment as ordinary life

The nations around Israel did not only bow to images. They read omens, cast spells, and talked to the dead. God calls that the reason He drove those nations out.

“There shall not be found among you anyone who burns his son or his daughter as an offering, anyone who practices divination or tells fortunes or interprets omens, or a sorcerer or a charmer or a medium

or a necromancer or one who inquires of the dead, for whoever does these things is an abomination to the LORD. And because of these abominations the LORD your God is driving them out before you.”

Deuteronomy 18:10–12

Isaiah says the same to a people tempted to whisper to mediums: should they not inquire of their God? Should the living inquire of the dead? (Isaiah 8:19). In Ephesus, the new believers brought their magic books and burned them in public, and the value was counted in silver (Acts 19:19).

That trade is back, and it is legal. The Pew Research Center’s Forum on Religion and Public Life, in “Many Americans Mix Multiple Faiths” (December 9, 2009), found that 25 percent of American adults believe astrology affects people’s lives, 23 percent of Christians among them. Twenty-six percent believe in spiritual energy in mountains, trees, or crystals. Nearly three in ten say they have felt in touch with someone who has died. Fifteen percent have consulted a fortuneteller or a psychic. Sixteen percent believe certain people can cast curses or spells. The shop sells it as spirituality. Deuteronomy sells it as the abomination of the nations. The First Amendment shelters the private practice. Nobody is jailing the astrologer. Cahn ties the spell-work to Ishtar as enchantress. The verse list in Deuteronomy 18 does not need his label. It already pairs the spells with the burning of the son and the daughter, in one sentence, as one culture.

7. The child, handed over, and the public calling it good

This is the practice the Bible treats as the bottom of the pit.

“They built the high places of Baal in the Valley of the Son of Hinnom, to offer up their sons and daughters to Molech, though I did not command them, nor did it enter into my mind, that they should do this abomination.”

Jeremiah 32:35

“You slaughtered my children and delivered them up as an offering by fire to them.”

Ezekiel 16:21

“They sacrificed their sons and their daughters to the demons; they poured out innocent blood, the blood of their sons and daughters, whom they sacrificed to the idols of Canaan, and the land was polluted with blood.”

Psalms 106:37–38

Deuteronomy 12:31 says the nations burn their sons and their daughters in the fire to their gods. Second Kings 16:3 and 21:6 say Ahaz and Manasseh made their sons pass through the fire. Second Kings 17:31 says the Sepharvites burned their children to Adrammelech and Anammelech. Second Kings 3:27 says the king of Moab offered his firstborn son as a burnt offering on the wall. Leviticus 20:4–5 says the nation that shuts its eyes and refuses to kill the practice will itself be cut off.

The archaeology of the tophet, the infant burial ground at Carthage and elsewhere, is argued in the journals. Lawrence E. Stager and Samuel R. Wolff, “Child Sacrifice at Carthage—Religious Rite or Population Control?” (*Biblical Archaeology Review*, January/February 1984), laid out the case that the urns hold sacrificed infants, not only children who died of disease. John Day, *Molech: A God of Human Sacrifice in the Old Testament* (Cambridge University Press, 1989), treats Molech as a god who received human sacrifice. Scholars who want a softer reading have to climb over the plain sense of Leviticus, Kings,

Jeremiah, Ezekiel, and the Psalms. The Bible is not unsure what the parents did. They killed their children for a god, and the culture defended it until a king defiled the pit.

The fire, the idol, and the drum are gone. The killing of the child, under parental consent and public permission, is abortion. The child in the womb is killed, and the killing is filed as medicine. *Roe v. Wade*, 410 U.S. 113 (1973), held that killing to be a constitutional right nationwide for fifty years. *Dobbs v. Jackson Women's Health Organization*, 597 U.S. 215 (2022), said the Constitution contains no such right and sent the question to the states and to Congress. Where a state still permits it, the culture guards it as healthcare, and interfering with it is the crime. Where a state has restricted it, the national argument has not ended. The practice is still protected culture in much of the country and in much of the West. It is the one practice on this list that is honestly contested in American law right now. Molech's name is not on the clinic. Jeremiah's charge does not require the name. It requires the child, the parent, and the nation's decision to look away.

8. The altar that is not protected, because it is not being held

What did not come back is the furniture. No American city maintains an Asherah pole beside a courthouse and dares a prophet to cut it down. No priesthood of Dagon sets up a fish-god and leans the nation's trophies on him. No one is openly burning a born child in the Valley of Hinnom to a statue called Molech. Baal's prophets are not cutting themselves with lances on a mountainside as the state religion (1 Kings 18:28). Josiah's reforms have no modern opposite in which the government reinstalls the male prostitutes' quarters inside the temple and weaves new hangings for a wooden goddess (2 Kings 23:4–7). Deuteronomy 12:2–3 still describes a job that, as far as the idols themselves go, is largely already done. The names fell. The high places of wood and stone fell with them.

A few reconstructionist pagans pray to Baal or Asherah in private. That is not a protected national cult. It is a small revival of the labels. The mass culture did something more effective. It kept the acts and retired the labels.

How a city protects a god

Acts 19 is the mechanism, and it is embarrassingly modern. Demetrius does not open a theology debate. He tells the craftsmen that their silver shrines of Artemis are the trade by which they get their wealth, and that Paul is a threat to the business and to the goddess “whom all Asia and the world worship” (Acts 19:25–27). The crowd does not chant a creed. For two hours it chants that Artemis of the Ephesians is great (Acts 19:34). The town clerk's answer is order, the courts, and the city's legal standing (Acts 19:35–41).

That is how a practice becomes “culture.” It is jobs. It is identity. It is the thing the city will riot to keep. Today the shelters have different captions: privacy, healthcare, equality, speech, the right to be left alone. Under those captions sit the emptied public altar, the sex trade in images and in the bed, the parade that flips male and female, the remade body, the fortune-teller, and the legal killing of the child in the womb. Ephesus would have understood the argument. It would not have understood why anyone pretended the goddess had left.

The count

Seven of the eight practices are surviving, and they are protected as culture.

One: the public square cleared of the God of Israel, guarded as neutrality since 1962 and 1963.

Two: sex outside the marriage covenant, no longer a crime, now the ordinary story of adult life.

Three: pornography, legal commerce in sexual images.

Four: public parades of gender inversion, protected speech, with marriage and employment law rewritten around the same inversion.

Five: medical remaking of the sexed body, legal for adults, pulled back for children in the United Kingdom and Sweden because the evidence failed.

Six: astrology, mediums, spells, and crystals, believed by tens of millions and sold in daylight. Pew's 2009 numbers are enough. A quarter of the country believes the stars steer a life.

Seven: abortion, the handing over of the child to death, a constitutional right from 1973 to 2022, and still a protected right in every state that has not closed the door.

Eight is only half gone. The named god, the pole, and the Topheth fire are not protected, because they are not being held in public. The temple prostitute's room is the piece that was miscounted. It is not on the statute books under that name. It is talked about, inside fraternal orders, as a trip to the temple for a blessing. Where that speech is only the name of a meeting hall, it is not the rite. Where the blessing is a sex act required for rank, it is the rite, and it has been written down. No one has counted the countries. The absence of a count is not the absence of the act.

The question in the title answers itself. We are not protecting Baal's statue. We are protecting Baal's work, Ishtar's parade, and Molech's bargain, and we have passed laws to punish anyone who treats those works as the abominations the Scriptures say they are. The shrine sex that buys standing is the part we still hide under a blessing.

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